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PIE *b^her- and "Slavo-Nostratic" Lexical Archaisms

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0 Introductory.

Many of V. M. Illič-Svityč's etymological treatments of the Nostratic lexicon as he reconstructed it (1971/1976/1984) claimed, quite reasonably, that some anomalous material in Indo-European (and elsewhere) might merely reflect archaic retentions, from the Nostratic point of view. Some of these allegedly archaic linguistic features are best described as being associated with particular lexical items, and many such so-called "lexical archaisms" in Slavic have been defended by M. Kaiser (1990). Among these, the best-known case (a Paradebeispiel among Nostratic scholars) concerns Illič-Svityč's assertion that the meaning 'take', as appears in the Slavic verb derived from IE *b^her- (a root otherwise assumed to mean 'bear, carry' and 'bring'), directly continues an inherited semantic archaism traceable to Nostratic (Kaiser 1990:37f., no. [5]). But a number of arguments suggest that the meaning 'take' for IE *b^her- is a Slavic innovation, and not a semantic archaism reflecting Nostratic semantics.[1]

It will be convenient to begin by citing Kaiser's entry *in extenso*:

"[5] Slavic *berǫ 'I take' < IE *b^{h}er- 'take, bring, carry' < Nst. **bari 'take': ... [*language distribution chart omitted* — BV] Illič-Svityč states that Slavic is the only IE language to retain the archaic meaning 'take'. On the other hand, Trubačev sees such Slavic forms as *berdja 'pregnant (of animals)' and *bermę 'pregnant'[2] as retaining archaic IE semantics, thereby implying that the semantics of the Slavic verb are an innovation. Inasmuch as *berdja and *bermę are clearly deverbative formations, the only satisfactory accounting for the developments in Slavic from the Nostratic point of view is to assume that IE (Slavic included) developed a secondary meaning 'carry' and concomitant deverbative formations. Most IE languages continued the semantic development to 'bring' while at the same time losing 'take', whereas Slavic reverted to 'take'. Inasmuch as the other IE languages are very uniform in their loss of 'take', Slavic must have broken apart from IE at about the time that these semantic innovations were in progress *and* prior to the break up of the other dialects, i.e., at a relatively early date. Of course this postulated early separation of Slavic from IE would have occurred after the separation of the Anatolian languages from IE. Dolgopolsky is the most recent of the many supporters of Sturtevant's Indo-Hittite hypothesis."

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[1] The importance attached to this particular case may be inferred from the inclusion of Illič-Svityč's Nostratic etymon ***bari* among only three entries from his Nostratic etymological dictionary published in English translation (Illič-Svityč 1989; in addition to IE *b^her- 'to take, bring, carry' [sic], Nostr. ***bari* is said to be supported [1971:176f., 1989:122] by Afro-Asiatic **br-* 'to seize, catch', Altaic **bari-* 'to take into one's hands', and [with a query] Dravidian **per-* 'to pick up, gather'). The IE form, its putative meanings, and the Slavic support for the primordial Nostratic sense 'take' figured prominently in V. Ševoroškin's synoptic presentation on "The History of Nostratic Scholarship" (1993, handout item 13), and is otherwise a staple of IE/Nostratic discussions.

[2] Sic; cf. §3. below, ad init.

Before addressing various points of detail, we may comment briefly and more generally on the unsatisfactory nature of the above argumentation. The key sentence, beginning "Inasmuch as *berdja ...", is simply a non sequitur (more on this point in §3. below), which is itself based on a false premise: the operative phrase is "from the Nostratic point of view", which then leads to the "assumption" about "the only satisfactory accounting" of the Slavic data. But what has not been provided is precisely an evaluation of the Slavic and Indo-European data on their own terms. Instead, we find a complex and in any case otherwise undocumented "Indo-Slavic" scenario (improperly asserted as fact, and not as hypothesis: "Slavic must have broken apart from IE ..."), based on the *a priori* assumption that the semantic divergence appearing in Slavic can only be explained on the basis of Nostratic.

The following four (to some extent interrelated) arguments arise from a more thorough consideration of Slavic and IE *$b^{h}er$-, and strongly suggest that the meaning 'take' is a Slavic innovation.

1 *b^{h}er- and IE suppletion.

It has long been known that the fundamentally durative root *$b^{h}er$- showed suppletive behavior in PIE, vis-à-vis one or more aoristic roots traditionally referred to via notations like *$Hnek$-. In a penetrating and important study, J. L. García Ramón has recently set the interpretation of this "*$Hnek$-" on a firm footing, in the process elucidating the PIE suppletive relations between *$b^{h}er$- and *h_2nek- 'erreichen, reichen bis' on the one hand (1999:55-6) and *$b^{h}er$- and *h_1nek- 'erhalten, (weg)nehmen' on the other (1999:56-7). While *$b^{h}er$- supplies, in Slavic, a full paradigm for a verb meaning 'collect, gather, take', "*$Hnek$-" (probably mainly *h_1nek-, although *h_2nek- may also be involved) likewise has its own full paradigm, providing the Slavic verb meaning 'carry, bear', as in OCS *nesǫ/nesti*; and the same situation, *mutatis mutandis*, appears in Baltic as well.[3] Thus, to interpret the meaning 'take' of Sl. *berǫ/bīrati* as a semantic archaism attributable to Nostratic is to neglect the entire conception of *$b^{h}er$- as a suppletive root, which has undergone in Slavic (and also in Baltic, an important fact not accounted for by the Nostraticist position) what until now has appeared to be a patently late formal and semantic redistribution, of a type well-documented in the development of suppletive systems. In order to overturn such a well-established framework of derivational relations among *$b^{h}er$- and its suppletive cohorts, very compelling reasons need to be provided, and none is forthcoming.[4]

[3] The details of the (pre-)Balto-Slavic suppletive relations, and the Baltic and Slavic synchronic patterns arising from them, have been convincingly analyzed by García Ramón (1999:67-9).

[4] Here we may note in passing the interesting observations of Hollifield (1977:99) on the semantics of six IE roots that make verbs of "bringing" (in his characterizations, *$b^{h}er$- 'carry in the hands', *$ǵeǵ^{h}$- 'convey on the back', *$ǵelk$- 'draw behind one', all referring to "objects moved by an extrinsic force", beside *$h_2eǵ$- 'drive (before one)', *$nejH$- 'lead (behind one, of animals)', and *$ǵed^{h}$- 'lead (behind one, of persons)', referring to "objects moved by their own energy"), in conjunction with their morphological behavior: "It is hardly to be thought an accident that all of these partial synonyms are conjugated as root thematic presents in Proto-Indo-European, and that they constitute the majority of the transitive thematic presents which one can show existed in the proto-language". The correspondences are striking, even if original thematic inflection may not be the best reconstruction for *$ǵelk$- (see now LIV s.v. 1. ***ǵelk**).

2 *The morphology of Sl. *berǫ.*

The morphology of Sl. *berǫ* (cf. especially OCS infin. *bīrati*) differs markedly from the rest of IE, in which *$b^{h}er$- shows both (a) an ordinary thematic present *$b^{h}ér$-e/o- (Gk. *φέρω*, Go. *bairan*, etc.), clearly to be reconstructed for PIE, and (b) certain forms of athematic inflection, attested only in traces (RV *bhárti* beside *bíbharti/bibhárti*, Gk. *φέρτε*, etc.), the precise analysis of which remains controversial (in addition to LIV s.v., see Jasanoff 1998:305f., arguing for an original acrostatic present). As demonstrated by Jasanoff (1983), Slavic **bīra-* (as in pret. and pres. infin.[5]) continues a preterite in *-ā-* (< PIE *$-é$-h_2-) originally associated with zero-grade presents (so-called *tudáti* presents), a type of preterite formation which only secondarily infiltrated the present infinitive. Thus OCS *berǫ/bīrati* belongs to a present type which arises from a morphological innovation within Slavic. Moreover, a pair like *berǫ/bīrati* would reflect, in this view, the latest stratum of this innovation, as shown by the *e*-grade vocalism of the finite present stem, vs. morphologically more archaic forms of the type Sl. **sičǫ/*sīcati* 'urinate' (Slov. *ščí-/scati*, Cz. *šti-/scáti*, Russ. *sci-/scat'*, cf. Toch. A *sik-* 'overflow', Av. 3pl. *frašicanti* 'pour forth'), showing the original zero-grade stem of a *tudáti* present.

There are, to be sure, other methods of accounting for the (Balto-)Slavic -ā-preterite: see e.g. Rasmussen 1986[1999], with further references. There remains, in any event, the fundamental descriptive fact that this formation is closely associated, in its origins, with zero grade of the root.[6] We again reach a situation where a form like **bīra-* can reflect nothing very old.[7] Thus, in a manner analogous to what was said in §1., the Slavic semantics of a verb that belongs to a morphologically innovatory present type (i.e., inherited full-grade thematic present beside zero-grade infinitive in -ā-) reflecting a late encroachment of a preterital formation (which in the case of *$b^{h}er$- cannot be inherited, cf. §1.) cannot reliably be compared directly to Nostratic material.

3 Sl. **berdja and *bermę.*

Kaiser appears to grant (but chooses to reinterpret) the traditional claim that certain Slavic nominal forms, which Kaiser cites as "*berdja 'pregnant (of animals)'" and "*bermę 'pregnant'", retain an archaic meaning 'bear, carry'. Let us first note that there is no such form as Sl. "*bermę" in the adjectival meaning 'pregnant': there has perhaps been some confusion between the neut. *men*-stem **bermę* 'burden' (OCS *brěmę*, Russ. *b(e)rémja*, SCr. *brȅme*, etc.) and the derived adjective seen in forms like Russ. *berémennaja* 'pregnant'.

In assessing Kaiser's reinterpretation, we must be clear about the significance of the Slavic nominal material itself. Although neither noted nor notated by Kaiser, the neut. *men*-stem *bermę shows lengthened grade, in Slavic terms (thus properly **bérmen-*, with Proto-Slavic acute intonation), as also in the frozen feminine with dental extension **bérdjā-* 'pregnant (esp. of animals)' (RCS *brěžda*, SCr. *brȅda*, Russ. *berëžaja*). The Slavic acute intonation, however it is to

[5] For the stem-variation: similarly *derǫ/dīrati* 'scrape, flay' and several others; details in Koch 1990:483ff.

[6] Cf. Rasmussen 1986[1999]:209 ("It is doubtless significant that the *ā*-preterite selects the zero-grade of the root"), with analysis of *-ā-*preterite forms in terms of the IE root aorist middle, a category with canonic zero grade.

[7] Even if the post-RV 2 du. imperat. forms *bhartám* (YV, TS, etc.) and *bhṛtám* (YV) are aoristic and not presential, which is not entirely clear (see LIV with n. 3), the root-aorist formation is not likely to be old.

be interpreted in IE terms,[8] is critical to the evaluation of these forms. While it is no doubt true that from an Indo-European point of view, forms such as these are in some sense, as Kaiser claims, "deverbative" (as is generally the case, for example, with neut. *men*-stems), not only is the acute intonation entirely lacking in the Slavic verb continued by OCS *berǫ/bīrati*, but traces of lengthened grade are also not to be found in virtually all IE verbal material belonging to this root.[9] This makes it absolutely certain that Sl. **bérmen-* is an isolated morphological archaism with no inner-Slavic derivational source; and it is well known in any event that neut. *men*-stems reflect, within Slavic, a small and unproductive class (only seven such items in canonic OCS texts) continuing largely inherited material (cf. perhaps, in fact, the lengthened grade of RV *bhā́rman* [VIII.2.8]), including other isolated and obviously inherited forms (OCS *imę* 'name', *sěmę* 'seed', etc.).[10] As such, then, Sl. **bérmen-* is precisely the sort of form that is likely to preserve archaic semantics; and conversely, it is a term whose semantics (to say nothing of its form) cannot be explained secondarily on the basis of developments within Slavic. Similar arguments apply, perhaps even *a fortiori*, to the Slavic form with *d*-extension. If, as is generally assumed, Sl. **bérdjā-* belongs with the isolated Latin fem. *forda* (*bos*) 'pregnant (of cows)' (with dialectal doublet *horda*), an archaic technical term associated with Italic Sakralsprache, then this form may have even greater claim to continuing an inherited archaism, both morphologically and semantically.[11]

Thus, just as the morphology of Sl. *berǫ/bīrati* (with meaning 'gather, take') is innovatory (§2.), the morphology of Sl. **bérmen-* and **bérdjā-* (which require a meaning 'carry') is archaic. From the point of view of normal procedures of historical/comparative reconstruction, from both the Slavic and Indo-European perspectives, there can be no justification for reversing the "face-value" interpretation of the concomitant semantics of these terms. Under these circumstances, the only way in which Sl. **bérmen-* and **bérdjā-* could be taken as deverbative formations that show "a secondary meaning 'carry'" to be reconstructed for the IE verb is precisely to view the matter, as Kaiser says, "from the Nostratic point of view" — which is simply to assert a reinterpretation of the IE material for which no actual arguments are provided, beyond a vague appeal to the "Indo-Hittite hypothesis".

[8] I.e., as pointing either to an actual lengthened grade (cf. §2. above for the possibility of an original acrostatic present *$b^{h}\acute{e}r$-*ti* beside plain thematic *$b^{h}\acute{e}r$-e/o-*), or conceivably to an alternate root-form *$b^{h}erH$- (see *EWAia* II.249 for discussion of both possibilities, with further references; cf. also next footnote).

[9] See Jasanoff 1998:305, citing Sl. **bérmen-*, among lengthened-grade nominal derivatives (also OHG *bāra* 'bier'), beside the more direct evidence of Toch. A (imperf.) *pārat* (a form not even mentioned in LIV) among data pointing to the reconstruction of an acrostatic present for this root.

[10] Whether the acute of Sl. **bérmen-* is actually to be equated with the lengthened grade of RV *bhā́rman* is of secondary importance here; references and discussion in *EWAia* (loc. cit., n. 8 above).

[11] In precisely these terms, see in detail ESSJ I.188 (s.v. **berdja**): "Praslav. **berdja* — tipičnyj arxaizm i relikt drevnej leksiki. Èto slovo soxranjaet drevnee znač. svoego komja *b^{h}er- — 'rožat', nosit' (vo čreve)'", etc.

4 IE phraseology.

The reconstruction of PIE culture, including religion and poetics (and especially poetic material embedded in archaic religious phraseology), often carries important consequences for more purely linguistic reconstruction. This point has recently been made in most eloquent fashion by Calvert Watkins (1995, passim), and hardly requires detailed demonstration. In the present case, there is general agreement that priestly titles of the sort "PV + *$b^{h}er$-" (in which the preverb normally indicates notions like 'forward, to(ward)', and in which the root typically appears in an agent-noun formation) reflect an inherited form of IE religious terminology — whence priestly titles of the sort Ved. *prá-bhartar-* ≈ YAv. *fra-bərətar-*, cf. Umbr. *ař-fertur*, and perhaps Messap. *tabara* (i.e. *ta-bara*, with PV **to-* + *$b^{h}er$-, as in Celtic: OIr. *do-beir*). Such archaic ritual terms, which may well go back to a common prototype, are certainly to be interpreted as 'offerer', i.e. 'one who carries/brings forward or towards' (cf. *EWAia* II.248f., with additional Indo-Iranian phraseological material), and not 'taker', 'gatherer' or the like.[12] Thus, lexical and phraseological data from the oldest stratum of Indo-European culture that can be reached by standard methods of linguistic comparison point to a meaning 'bring, carry' for IE *$b^{h}er$-, and not 'take'.

5 Concluding remarks.

The "Nostratic" interpretation of the meaning 'take' seen in the Slavic verb that continues IE *$b^{h}er$- is therefore to be rejected. But this result constitutes neither a rejection of the Nostratic hypothesis, nor even of the proposed Nostratic etymology that aligns IE *$b^{h}er$- with possible non-IE cognates. Indeed, it has the effect of simplifying the proposed Nostratic etymology: in clarifying the IE and Slavic situation with *$b^{h}er$-, as above, the Nostratic etymology (if it can be supported on other grounds) can now eliminate the complex and unlikely scenario that must be claimed in order to account for the Slavic data in terms of Nostratic, instead of via innovations within Slavic. In Nostratic terms, then, the analysis of *$b^{h}er$- assumed here (i.e., the traditional one) has the effect of dating the otherwise typologically natural semantic innovation 'take' > 'bring, carry' (cf. Hollifield 1977:99f.) to the (pre-)Proto-Indo-European period, which poses no significant problem for the etymology itself, and — insofar as the weak and problematic claims about preservation of Nostratic semantics in Slavic have been eliminated — may actually strengthen it.

Nor does the above analysis imply *ipso facto* the rejection of all other cases of alleged "lexical archaism" in Slavic, although in my view nearly all such cases offered by Kaiser (1990) are unlikely to be valid, a point that cannot of course be pursued within the compass of this presentation. But even if most of these claims must ultimately be rejected, several may have merit. Thus Kaiser's item no. 153 (1990:95), although thus far not trumpeted by Nostraticists, may well be among the most suggestive such cases: here Slavic shows not a semantic, but rather a formal feature that appears to align it more closely with Nostratic (as against the rest of IE), namely the preservation of unsuffixed (or unenlarged) forms of IE *$del(h_1)$- 'long' (beside the

[12] See especially Campanile 1983:220 (with earlier references) on this "protoforma" consisting of "*nomen agentis* dalla radice *b^{h}er- con prefisso allativo" and the "denominazione indocuropea del sacerdote" as "colui che porta l'offerta innanzi agli altri". (The Messapic form has been interpreted in an entirely different way, on which see recently Huld 1995; this does not, of course, invalidate the general point being made here.)

form with velar element seen in OCS *dlũgŭ*, Ved. *dīrghá-*, Gk. *δολιχός*, Hitt. *daluki-*, etc.), cf. the Nostratic reconstruction ***tel(h)V* 'long' (unfortunately based on non-IE material attested with certainty only in Altaic). Again, however, the situation is rather more complex than Kaiser's lemma indicates, since IE **dl̥h₁-gʰó-* (and the forms with secondary full grades somehow based on it) are probably to be connected with the other word (or other form of the word) for 'long' that appears in Lat. *longus* and Gmc. **langa-*, and which may continue a still poorly-understood agglutination (roughly) **dl(h₁)-on-gʰ-o-*. Such a nexus of obscure morphological correlations, in which the simpler Slavic material has a more obviously primordial appearance, holds far more promise for the Nostratic enterprise, and more specifically for the role in it played by Slavic material, than any number of dubious claims about semantic "lexical archaisms".

The preceding represents an updated version of part of a draft for a project proposal, originally written (in 1994) in consultation with my friend and colleague Alexis Manaster Ramer. I am indebted to him not only for his comments on the earlier draft (and it goes without saying that he does not necessarily agree with what appears in this version), but in general for his inspiration and guidance in connection with my earlier lucubrations on *res Nostraticae* (1991, 1998), and for incisive discussions of many points of Indo-European grammar besides. The collaborative part of our work on the project in question would have involved a thorough reassessment of the Indo-European component in Nostratic, and I am sorry that this opportunity did not materialize. But I am delighted to help celebrate the contributions, both personal and academic, of Alexis Manaster Ramer: brilliant scholar, tenacious interlocutor, and real mensch.

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